

THE RED PLANET



Viking spacecraft

The Viking lander is folded into a capsule on the spacecraft.



It leaves the orbiter and begins its journey down to Mars.

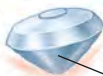
Mars is called the Red Planet because its soil and rocks are red. Light winds blow dust around, which makes the sky look pink. People once thought there was life on Mars, but nothing living has been found so far.

The Viking spacecraft were sent to Mars to find out what it is like. Two missions, Viking 1 and Viking 2, made the journey.

Perhaps one day people may go to live on Mars because it is the planet most like our own.



The television camera takes a series of pictures as it moves around.



It moves so fast that it gets very hot.



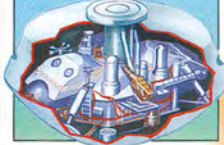
A parachute is used to slow it down, and then the heat shield drops off.

This remote control arm is used to collect samples of Mars soil.

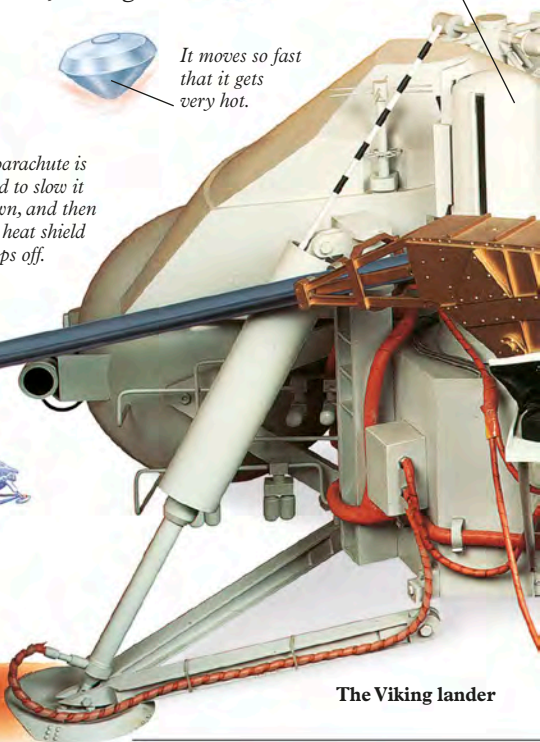


Tight fit

The Viking lander fits into a capsule on the spacecraft. With its legs folded up, it looks a bit like a tortoise inside its shell.



The legs unfold, and rockets are used as brakes for a soft landing.



The Viking lander